

# R.I.P. Internet

**WHILE WRITING THE COVER STORY FOR THIS MONTH**, one of the points I wanted to write about was what the internet would look like in 2030. Why 2030? Given that all those who care to make predictions suggest that about 88% of the world's population will be online by then (7.5 billion of 8.5 billion), it seemed apt to envision the way it would work then. There are the obvious predictions about it being essentially a mobile-only Internet, with almost nothing that PC users could exclusively do. Then there's the Internet of Things to consider, which will run on pretty much every device made. But these are low hanging fruit in the soothsayer's garden. Most predictions are too positive and almost hell bent on spreading feel-good love. This column will do the opposite.

I think the Internet as we know it will cease to exist; and that's a bad thing. The whole idea of the Internet is connectivity, exposing ideas to billions and communicating with one another, learning from one another. Obviously, that isn't going to stop, but I foresee it being mostly in institutes and academia rather than being mainstream. The internet is already showing fault-lines in places where monopolies exist, and I see it completely fracturing and being broken up into continents. No, obviously I don't mean physical continents like on a map, but digital continents based on what services a person uses or is hooked on.

Facebook is a walled garden that others cannot breach, Twitter is the same. Apple have their own ecosystem that they're trying to lock you into, and screaming about privacy (that doesn't even exist anymore) is their way of shepherding you into their little paddock. Google isn't far behind, and wants to do exactly the same...

I still remember the WWW, and how it was open to all, and a very novel idea. It was just mind-blowing to us at the time that you could look at pictures from across the globe, and read someone's project on MIT – things that we never dreamed possible. Messaging services ruled at the time because real-time conversations (even if they were only text) were revolutionary. Web 2.0 came along and changed everything again, and Wikipedia was the crowning achievement of that era for me. Social networking was the worst!

By 2030, I expect we will have pretty decent AI, which will make the web semantic, but will anyone care? The Internet is merely another word for connectivity to an app now, and not the global connectivity we like to think of it as. Sure, using

your broadband connection, you could visit any server across the globe that was publicly serving up content or information. But do you? We all frequent very few places and have pretty fixed routines. I might love YouTube and spend hours a day there, watching content that the YouTube algorithm suggested, while you might spend hours on Discord as you game, or on Facebook, or trying to become a TikTok star... And we shall never meet. Heck, because I'm in a different geographical region, I often don't even see the same search results as you – even when I use the exact same keyword! That's Google's algorithm at work, trying to make content more relevant to us. Unless you found me on Facebook (young people don't use that anymore, right?), would we ever really interact? We had a better chance of doing so in the good old Web 2.0 days when you would leave comments on my articles, or chat with me on IRC, on the digit forum, etc.

Now imagine the next 4 billion coming online. With all the languages they bring, the dialects, and their million different interest areas and differing needs... do you think that will bring us together, or actually end up fracturing the net even more?

Just as we have arbitrary lines across continents that divide us up based on country, we will have the equivalent online. Yes, it's already happening, but the divide will be much bigger. We will be sliced and diced into the equivalent of states and cities based on our languages, interests, skills, etc. Even what we want to do for fun might be very different.

How is this different from now? It's not that different, except that my assumption is that AI will improve drastically a decade from now, and thus keep you hooked using whatever flavour of bait works best...Thanks to the push of more 'offline' apps, and also perhaps some companies giving in to the temptation to physically fracture the net into smaller networks, (perhaps using "security" as a concern), I expect we will stop being able to universally 'connect' as well.

In the end, the "Internet" that was envisioned all those years ago may not exist, and while that is not necessarily a bad thing, it will certainly be a sad thing. This has been coming for the past decade or so now, and there's nothing that will stop it. The real question is, will you even care? So long as you get precision targeted content and services that make you happy, will it bother you if it's from a walled off part of "the Internet"? 



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